Two-Dimensional Memtransistors: Modeling and Simulation for Circuit Design

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Table of Contents

1. Introduction
2. Need and Motivation
3. Literature Review
4. Research Gaps
5. Current Work
6. Simulation result
7. Post Programing pulse state
8. Challenges in Current Work
9. Outline of the Next Research Plan
10. References

Introduction

- **Memtransistor Structure** : A three-terminal hybrid device (source, drain, gate) that merges memristor's non-volatile memory with transistor's gate-tunable conductance.
- **Independent Read/Write**: The gate terminal lets us control reading and writing separately, unlike memristors.
- **Enhanced Functionality** : Works as both memory and logic helps overcome the von Neumann bottleneck by reducing the gap between memory and processor.
- **Reduced Complexity**: Memtransistors eliminate the need for extra selector transistors that are required in memristor crossbar arrays to access individual memory cells. This leads to more area- and energy-efficient designs.

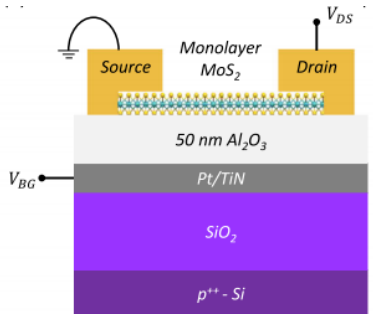


Figure: 2D Back gated memtransistor[1]

Need and Motivation

- **Need of Memtransistor**
  - **The von Neumann Bottleneck** : In traditional computers, CPU and memory are separate. Continuous data transfer between them slows performance and wastes energy.
  - **Energy Challenge :** For data-heavy tasks (e.g., AI, ML), this back-and-forth consumes enormous energy.
  - **Need for In-Memory Computing:** To solve this, computation must happen inside the memory itself, reducing data movement and improving efficiency.

- **Motivation**
  - By developing memtransistor-based systems, we can enable faster, smarter, and energy-efficient electronics for future AI and IoT applications.
  - High Scalability : The use of atomically thin MoS2 allows for aggressive dimensional scaling.
  - Brain-inspired neuromorphic computing for applications like real-time seizure detection.
  - Chip Fingerprints (PUFs): Tiny, unavoidable variations during the manufacturing of MoS2 create a unique physical "fingerprint" for every single chip. This identity is impossible to clone, preventing counterfeit copies.

Literature Review

Working Mechanism of Memtransistors

- Operate mainly through charge trapping at MoS2/oxide interface and in oxide near interface (storing charges in traps) or resistive switching (changing resistance states).
- These mechanisms allow them to store information non-volatilely.

Role of 2D Materials

- Molybdenum Disulfide (MoS2) is one of the most promising channel materials for memtransistors.
- Its atomically thin structure makes it suitable for ultra-scaled devices.
- MoS2 is only 0.7 nm thick (monolayer).
- Enables smaller and denser devices compared to silicon.

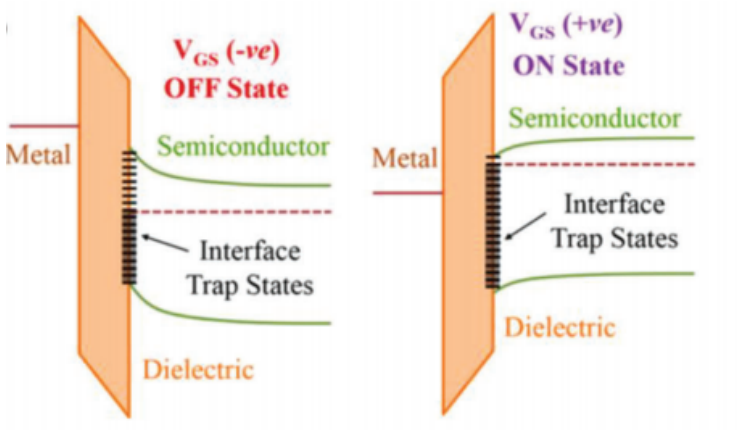


Figure: Trapping and Detrapping[3]

Cont.

Hardware implementation of Bayesian network based on two-dimensional memtransistors
(Publication: Nature Communications (2022)

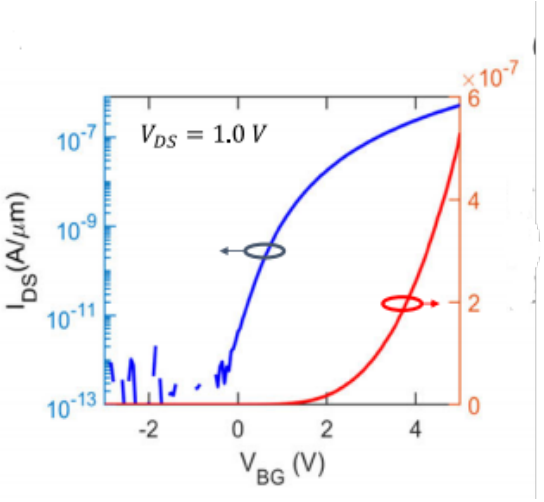


Figure: Transfer characteristics, i.e., source-to-drain current (IDS) vs(VBG), (VDS) of 1 V, in linear and logarithmic scale[1]

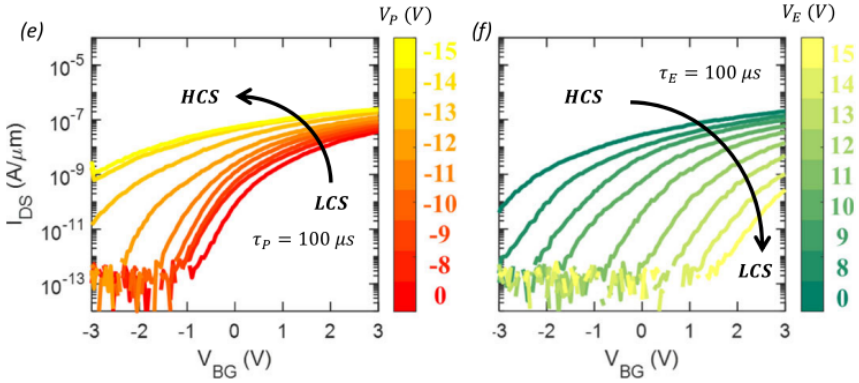


Figure: Id vs Vgs post programming pulse .Experimentalresult Log scale(X axis: gate voltage, Y axis Drain current)[1]

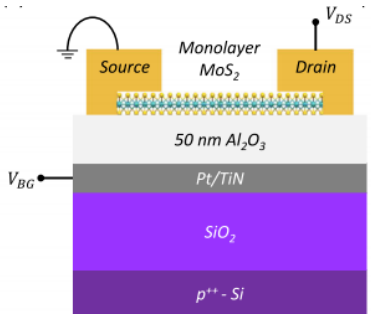


Figure: 2D-MoS2 based Memtransistor[1]

- Channel: Monolayer Molybdenum Disulfide (MoS2) .
- Gate: A local back-gate structure with a 50 nm Aluminum Oxide (Al2O3) charge trapping dielectric on a 40/30 nm Platinum/Titanium Nitride (Pt/TiN) electrode.
- Contacts: Nickel (Ni) and Gold (Au) are used for the source and drain.
- Substrate: The device is built on a SiO2/p++-Si substrate.

Dielectric Engineering: HfO_2 vs. Al_2O_3

- **Stronger Gate Control (High-k Effect):** HfO_2 possesses higher dielectric constant (ϵ_r) this significantly increases the gate capacitance, allowing the stronger gate control over the remote MoS_2 channel.
- **Intrinsic Defectivity:** The crystal structure of HfO_2 is inherently unstable, making it highly prone to forming stable oxygen vacancies during deposition.
- **Enhanced memory window:** These structural vacancies in HfO_2 function as deep **bulk** charge traps, enabling a far higher volume of storage and hence increase memory window.
- **Key Advantage of Al2O$_3$ over HfO$_2$:** Due to Al2O$_3$ large bandgap (8.8eV), which minimizes leakage current and ensure stable conductance state.

Interface traps and bulk traps

- **Interface Traps state At MoS2/HfO2:** These traps sit directly at the MoS2–HfO2 interface and interact instantly with the channel through SRH capture/emission. They mainly degrade current and mobility but cannot store charge for long.
- **Oxide Traps state** :
  Located within the HfO2 dielectric volume, physically separated from the MoS2 bands. Can retain charge for long periods, making them the dominant mechanism enabling stable, non-volatile memory storage.

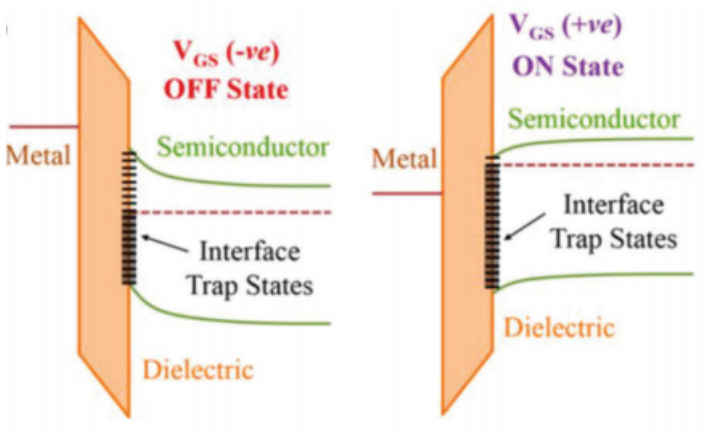


Figure: Interface trap states[2]

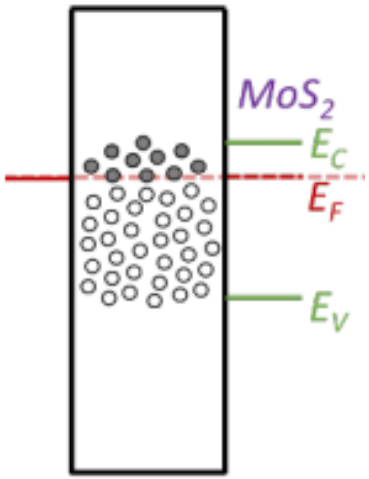


Figure: Oxide trap states[1]

Research Gaps

Experimental-Based Challenges

- It's still hard to make large, uniform, defect-free wafers of 2D materials like MoS2
- Fabrication imperfections cause variability in performance(Device to Device).
- Forming low-resistance electrical contacts with atomically thin channels is difficult.High contact resistance wastes power and reduces speed,performance.

Simulation-Based Research Gaps

- Need precise modeling of material properties and interface physics before fabrication .
- Need models that capture charge traps, contact resistance, and defects to bridge the gap between ideal simulations and experiments.

Current work

Device structure :

- The device is a three-terminal transistor-like structure based on monolayer MoS2..
- Substrate (SiO2 / p++Si) 285 nm SiO2 grown on heavily doped p++ silicon.
- Local Back-Gate (Pt 40nm TiN 3Onm with HfO2 25nm): The back-gate terminal is where programming and erasing pulses are applied.
- Channel (Monolayer MoS2 0.65nm): 2D material thickness (sub-nm scale) ensures excellent gate electrostatics.
- A 40nm Titanium metal is used as source and drain .

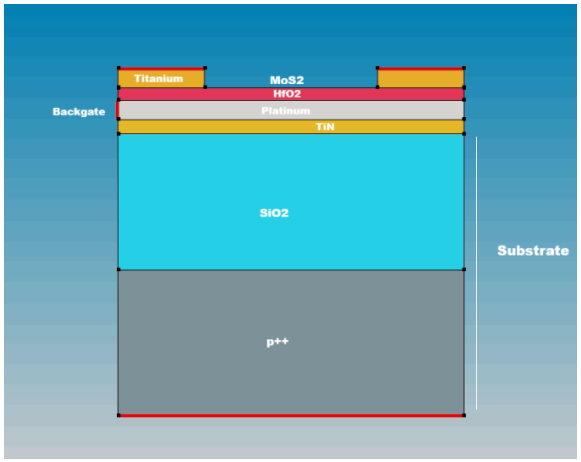


Figure: 2D Device structure sde

TCAD Physics models used

Trap Location	TCAD Model	Role in Operation	Trapping Physics	Parameters Used
MoS_2/HfO_2 Interface	Donor uniform, Acceptor uniform (10^{12} cm^{-2})	Primary function is to cause mobility degradation.	Shockley–Read–Hall (SRH) kinetics (local capture)	1.0×10^{-15} cm^2 cross-sections
HfO_2 Bulk (25 nm)	Acceptor Gaussian (e^- trap)	Erase operation; stores negative charge (5×10^{18} cm^{-3})	eBarrierTunneling Poole–Frenkel (Detrapping)	$E_{mid} = 1.0$ eV from E_C
HfO_2 Bulk (25 nm)	Donor Gaussian (h^+ trap)	Program operation; stores positive charge (1×10^{18} cm^{-3})	hBarrierTunneling and Poole–Frenkel (Detrapping)	$E_{mid} = 1.5$ eV from E_V

Table: Summary of trap locations, TCAD models, trapping physics, and parameters used.

Simulation result

Id vs Vgs characteristic

Parameter	Al_2O_3 Device	HfO_2 Device
Permittivity (ε_r)	≈ 9	≈ 25
Threshold Voltage (V_{th})	≈ 1.7 V	Lower 1.2V
I_{ON}	$\approx 6 \times 10^{-7}$ A/μm	1×10^{-5} A/μm
I_{OFF}	$\approx 10^{-13}$ A/μm	slightly higher 10^{-11} A/μm

Table: Comparison of Al_2O_3 and HfO_2 Devices

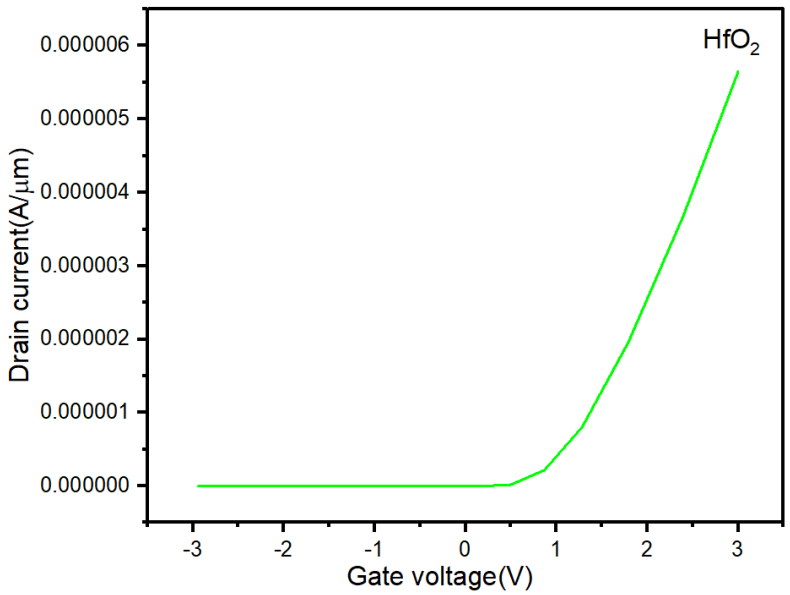


Figure: Ids vs Vgs linear scale

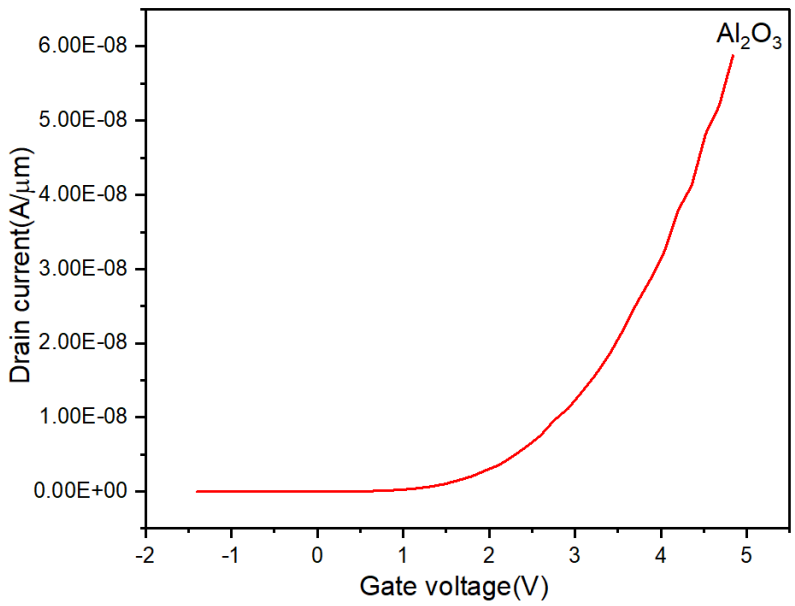


Figure: Id vs Vgs linear scale

Id vs Vgs characteristic at different trap concentration

Id vs Vgs characteristic

- Varied the donor trap concentration in the HfO2 bulk.
- Gate voltage sweep from -3v to 5v with Vds=1v.
- Current increases with increase in donor trap concentration and vth decreases.

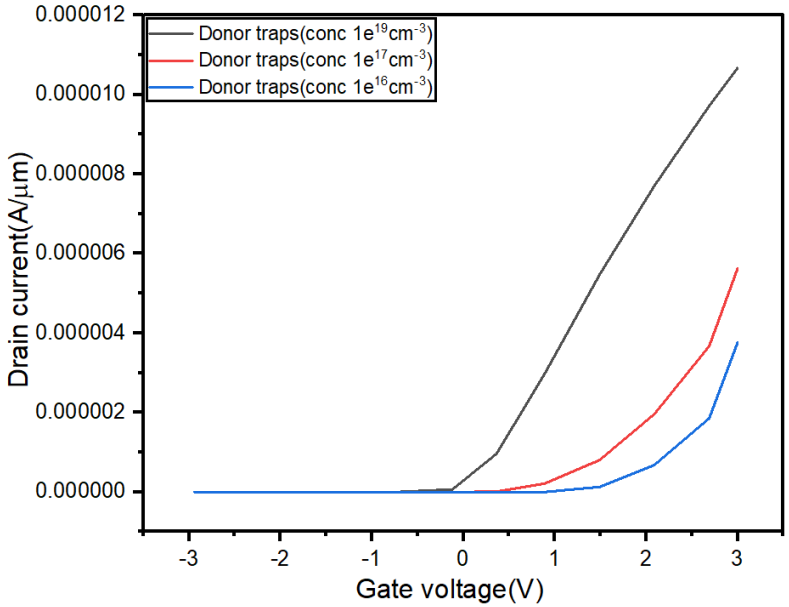


Figure: Ids vs Vgs linear scale

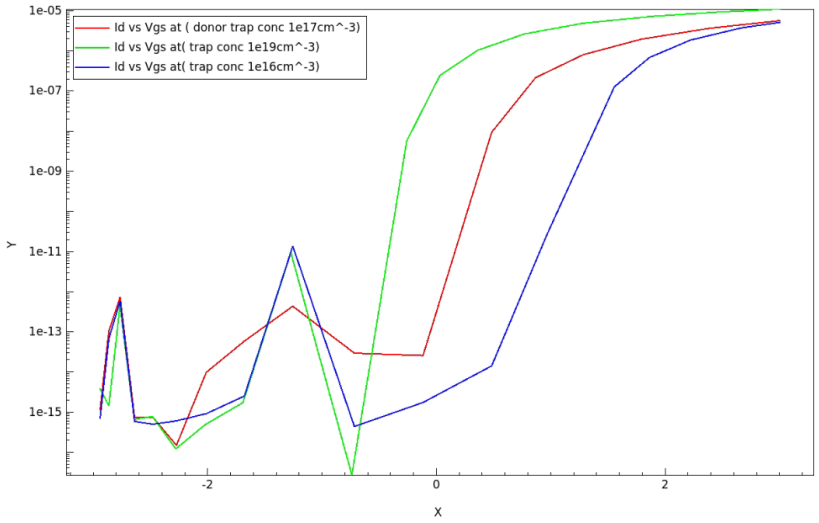


Figure: Id vs Vgs log scale

Post Programing pulse state

- VP voltage pulses of different amplitudes -7 V to -10 V applied to the local back-gate electrode, each for a duration of P=E = 100 μs,
- Post progammed state Id vs Vgs . .

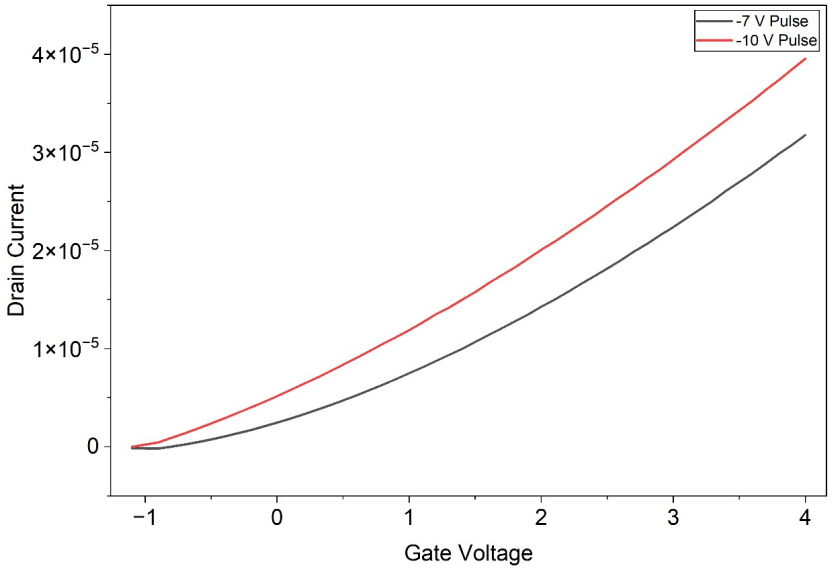


Figure: Ids vs Vgs linear scale post program state

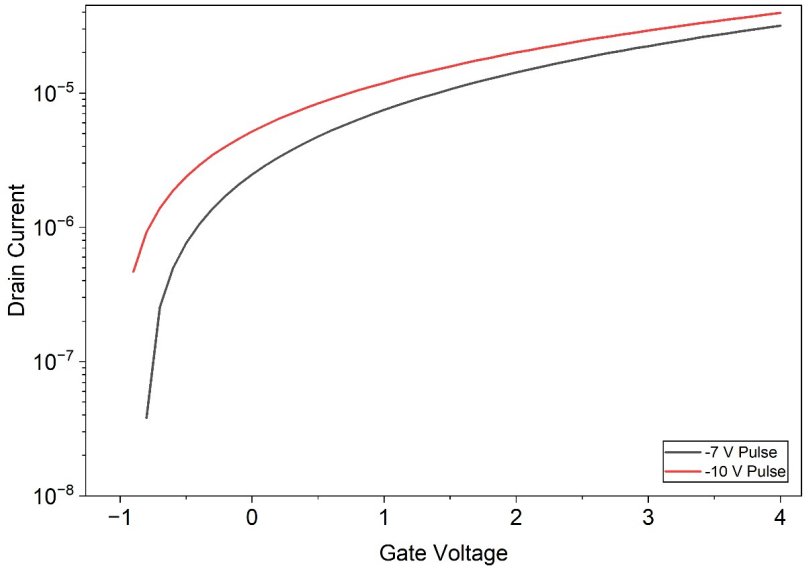


Figure: Id vs Vgs log scale post program state

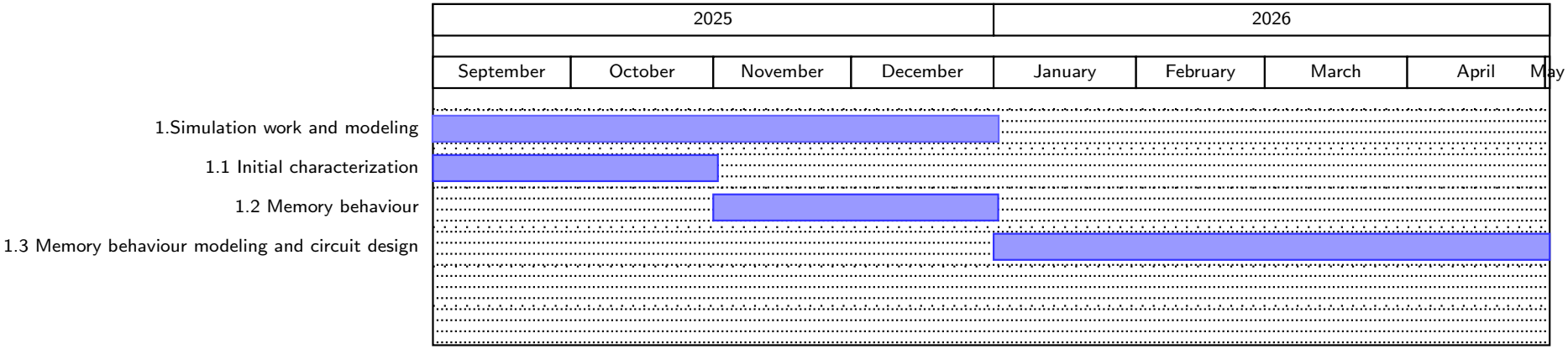
Challenges in Current work

The following are the current challenges:.

- It's very difficult for the simulation to accurately capture the effect of very fast and powerful voltage pulses (programing and erase).
- Creating a mesh that is fine enough for numerical stability without making computational cost .
- Non linear physics causes the solution to diverge rapidly.

Outline of the Next Research Plan

Work Breakdown Structure (September 2025 - May 2026)



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